



Figure 4: An ideal distribution for internet PCs

RPM file by double-clicking on it. I had to download KPackage to be able to install RPMs without any hassle. (Editor's Note: Boy, and I though Synaptic as the default package manager was a seller—at least for most people :-))

The repositories have really old software. It beats me that PCLinuxOS still uses printer-drake, something that has been discontinued even by Mandriva, which maintained it. Unfortunately, I did not have a printer nearby to test its functionality.

Fortunately, there's something good about the distro, too. PCLOS Control Centre shows some good improvements, including changes to how networking, firewalls, proxy and shares are handled. Software load times are very good, at least compared to Mandriva and openSUSE. Moreover, since I use the 'printscreens' a lot everyday, finding the button automatically configured with KSnapshot brought a smile in my face, right away.

Bundled software

The desktop version of PCLinuxOS 2009.1 has exactly the same number of software as on the LiveCD. Moreover, it is just the sweet spot for the 'migrators' since the distro doesn't pack in as many software as in Mint and Sabayon, but neither is it as bare as in MiniMe.

One function that won my heart

is the option to create a LiveCD and LiveUSB on-the-fly. While I created a LiveUSB of PCLOS itself, I have a feeling that the tool shall allow one to create a LiveUSB of any distro, since it asked me for the image file of the operating system.

Compatibility issues

I, personally, didn't find a single compatibility issue with PCLOS.

Every single piece of hardware on my laptop got detected seamlessly by the operating system. Besides, since I need to use ndiswrapper for the wireless adaptor, PCLOS actually gave me options to choose the one that's for me and went on to install it without a hitch!

I just wish the DVD drive of my personal computer was in working condition, because I was very interested to check out how easy/difficult it gets to detect my Web cam.

Multimedia capabilities

I must admit, I was blown away by the distro's multimedia capabilities. It didn't matter which audio or video file I threw at it, PCLOS managed to play it with absolute *elan*. All my MP4 and AVI files worked out of the box. It was also good to see KMPayer as the default video player, and not Kaffeine. My only complaint... I wish VLC and SMPlayer were also bundled with the distribution.

PCLOS for an Internet PC

PCLinuxOS 2009.1 is the perfect GNU/Linux distribution to be installed in an Internet PC. With the latest craze for this genre of computers and with the attempts to reduce their retail prices, PCLOS should be an automatic choice. It comes with the latest versions of Mozilla Firefox and Thunderbird. That takes care of the browsing and e-mail needs. For IM, there's always Kopete to bail you out. Yet, a desire for Pidgin does keep simmering. What's more, it also has Flash already installed in it. So, one can start YouTube right away, without the hassle of downloading the plug-in separately, as is the case with almost every other operating system! Also, apart from KTorrent,

PCLOS also has FrostWire to take care of your downloading needs. However, beware! Just like proprietary software, unauthorised downloading of movies and audio files is still a criminal offence.

For a distro version that took two years to launch, the level of development is zilch. Moreover, I found PCLinuxOS 2009.1 a bit behind the times in a few areas.

Rounding off

Although PCLinuxOS 2009.1 is absolutely solid and recommendable to one and all, the latest artwork is an absolute turn off. I have been using Mandriva 2009 for quite some time now, with KDE 4.2 on it, and had wanted to shift to another distro for a few weeks. However, the very looks of PCLOS 2009 forced me to stay put with Mandy and bide my time for the Spring Edition. Otherwise, if you are looking out for just plain functionality and do not give a hoot about how your operating system looks, you should be one very happy PCLinuxOS user, for sure! **END** 

PCLinuxOS 2009.1



Pros: Painless Installation, pre-loaded ndiswrapper drivers, well-organised Control Center, Software bundle, Audio/Video Codecs Support, Rock Stable.

Cons: Pathetic Artwork, RPMs can't be installed with double-clicks, unoptimised Compiz, KDE 4.2 absent.

Platform: x86

Price: Free (as in beer)

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An avid Twitter user and a social media enthusiast, the author is a passionate blogger and a professional gamer too. He also feels compelled to be opinionated about anything that comes his way, be it Linux distributions, our marketing strategies, table etiquettes or even the fabled Ramsay movies!